

Conveyor Panic

Status: In Development | Engine: Unity 2D | Platform: WebGL (target)

Overview

Conveyor Panic is a 2D arcade mini-game in the style of Mario Party. Items slide along a conveyor belt and the player must physically pick them up and run them to the correct bin before they fall off the end. The goal is chaotic fun that should still feel manageable. It should never feel impossible, just hectic.

Core Design Goals

- Chaotic but fair. The game should feel frantic without tipping into frustrating
- Player movement is the core mechanic as items are sorted by physically running them to bins, not clicking or dragging items.
- Short session length. 60 second rounds keep it punchy and replayable
- Clear visuals. Players should instantly know what to pick up and where to bring it.

Current State

- Player character moves with WASD or arrow keys, picks up items with Space
- Two item types on the belt: fruit (orange circle) and junk (purple square)
- Two bins, one on each side of the screen: Fruit bin on the left, Junk bin on the right.
- Items spawn at the left of the belt and slide right and are destroyed if they reach the end without being picked up.
- If the player sorts the item correctly, they get 10 points.
- If the player sorts the item incorrectly, they lose 5 points.
- If the player misses an item, they lose 3 points.
- There is a combo multiplier that stacks up to 5x for consecutive correct sorts. This resets on any mistake.
- If the player sorts the item in the wrong bin the screen shakes.
- 60 second countdown timer
- Game over screen with final score and a Play Again button

Design Decisions Chosen

- Reduced from 3 item types and 3 bins down to 2. This felt cleaner and a better balance for players.
- Moved bins to opposite sides of the screen instead of a row at the bottom. This gives the player room to move and makes every sort a longer run across the screen
- Chose physical carry mechanic over click-to-sort. This is more in keeping with a Mario Party style minigame. It's more engaging and fun

- Conveyor belt is placed in the centre of the screen player can run above and below it freely
- Items destroyed when they reach the end of the belt.

Known Issues to Fix

- Too many items appearing on the belt at once where it's not possible to keep up. In order to find a good balance this needs playtesting.
- Item spawn speed ramps up too fast. The starting interval needs to be slower
- Combo text is too large and too central. It needs to be a small unobtrusive indicator, it shouldn't be in the way of the game.
- Game over screen layout is messy. Some UI elements need to be smaller so the screen is neater.

Decisions To Be Made

- Spawn rate and difficulty curve. This needs manual playtesting to get the balance right as it's currently too fast
- Visual polish. The game is currently using shapes as placeholder items. Placeholder shapes should be replaced with sprites in the future.
- If a start screen should be added before the game begins

